

FREE TICKET
CM Siddaramaiah and deputy CM D.K. Shivakumar launch the 'Shakti' scheme for women in Bengaluru, Jun. 11

using 200 units a month; and Shakti, which entitles women to free rides on state transport buses. A fifth guarantee, Yuva Nidhi, incorporating an unemployment dole to graduates and diploma-holders, is expected to roll out early next year.

In the Gruha Lakshmi Yojana, officials had expected enrolment to pick up gradually, but even at the launch of the scheme on August 30, over 10 million applications had been received. As of October, there were 11.6 million registered beneficiaries of the scheme. This makes Gruha Lakshmi among the largest DBT programmes in the country, with the current fiscal's grant pegged at Rs 17,500 crore.

In the case of Shakti, the state budget had earmarked Rs 2,800 crore for it this fiscal, but by November 23, transport corporations had already issued zero-fare tickets worth Rs 2,413 crore to women passengers. While passenger volumes have more or less stabilised since, the scheme could exceed the budgetary outlay by Rs 1,000 crore, according to transport minister R. Ramalinga Reddy.

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PROMISES TO KEEP

Has the Congress, then, bitten off more than it can chew? The rollout of these 'guarantees' was a significant experiment of sorts—in terms of scale, implementation and fiscal burden. And not the least for their electoral potential, given the competitive populism every political party is engaged in. Expectedly, in the fortnight leading up to poll season, the political slugfest picked up in Karnataka with the Opposition trying to discredit the Congress's guarantees and the latter putting out newspaper advertisements detailing the achievements. These ads, which also reached poll-bound Telangana, drew the attention of the Election Commission for violating the model code of conduct. In mid-November, as Siddaramaiah and his deputy D.K. Shivakumar canvassed